



PAUCITY OF CLUES: NSG commandos examine a blast site in Ahmedabad

for Home Amit Shah puts it: "The blasts were planned to cause optimum terror. The most powerful were reserved for the end to target the injured and their relatives and friends rushing to the hospitals." Gujarat was literally on tenterhooks even after the blasts as a series of unexploded bombs were recovered by police from Ahmedabad and Surat, from where two abandoned WagonRs, laden with bombs, were also seized. Thankfully, the other powerful blast in the city's L.G. Governmental Hospital, in which a Maruti WagonR, loaded with a bomb and three gas cylinders, failed to cause any human damage.

That, however, is little consolation for the families of the dead and severely injured. One of them is VHP leader Laxmanji Chudasama, 46. He and

THE BOMB PLOT

In May, around 40 Muslim boys, 23 of them from Gujarat, took terror lessons from HUJI operatives at an obscure spot in central part of the state. The three-day HUJI meeting went undetected by both the Central and state intelligence agencies. The Government admits it was a serious failure. Though intelligence sleuths are trying to gather clues about this meet, they believe the seeds of the Ahmedabad blasts might have been sown here.

The meeting, according to intelligence sleuths, who are putting together the jigsaw puzzle, was organised by that group of HUJI which was also responsible for blasts in Jaipur in May. The group is based somewhere in Maharashtra and is led by a one-eyed commander.

Hours after the blasts, Ahmedabad police arrested Abdul Halim, maulvi of the radical Ahle Hadis tanzeem. He was suspected of directing some boys to attend this meet. Police are looking for the youth who participated in the meet. The nature and magnitude of the Ahmedabad blasts show these could not have been effected without the involvement of at least 50 local youths. The agencies believe it was planned by HUJI and executed by SIMI now called the Indian Mujahideen. "Except for the main directors who are from the ISI-supported HUJI, it is a home-grown terror movement in which local boys are trained by SIMI in bomb-making," says a sleuth.

another VHP worker Dinesh brought two dead bodies and two injured from the Bapunagar blast site to the Trauma Centre when Chudasama saw a blue spark in front of him. Sensing trouble, he immediately dropped flat on the ground. Next, he heard a deafening blast. He raised his head to find himself soaked in blood from splinters in his hands and legs. Everywhere around him were mangled bodies. "It is a scene which will forever remain embedded in my mind," he says. Only later did he realise that the bomb had been placed in a Maruti van at the Trauma Centre's entrance.

Another volunteer was Mukesh Lalani, 59, who was in the hospital for some other work when he rushed to help blast victims being brought to the Trauma Centre. When he was removing a pa-

The five minute e-mail warning and the targeting of hospitals located near the blast sites raise the terror bar to a new and frightening level.